

Beyond Outbidding: How Transnational Jihadists Reshape Competitive Violent Markets

Mark Berlin*

Ilayda B. Onder†

Abstract

How does the presence of transnational jihadist rivals shape the behavior of other armed groups in a conflict zone? In recent years, numerous jihadist organizations have pledged allegiance to al-Qaeda (AQ) or the Islamic State (IS). A prominent strand of research argues that increased competition may lead armed groups to escalate their violence to distinguish their “brand.” However, existing research has largely overlooked how the *type* of actor—rather than the quantity—involved in conflicts shapes competitive dynamics. In contrast to violent outbidding, we propose a theory of *restrained competition*, where local groups moderate violence against civilians to distinguish themselves from extremist rivals and boost their local support and international appeal. Using original data on pledges to AQ and IS, and leveraging their sudden emergence as a quasi-experimental treatment, we apply a Difference-in-Differences (DiD) analysis. Aligning with our *restrained competition* theory, we find that armed groups—particularly those with non-religious ideologies and that are not designated as terrorist organizations by the United States—reduce violence against civilians in response to transnational jihadist competitors. Our findings challenge assumptions about escalation in fragmented conflicts, offering new insights into armed group behavior.

Keywords: militant competition, violence against civilians, outbidding, strategic restraint, transnational jihadist networks

11,999 Words

*Postdoctoral Research Associate, Princeton University. markberlin@princeton.edu.

†Assistant Professor, Texas A&M University. ilaydaonder@tamu.com.

Introduction

Over recent decades, dozens of jihadist organizations pledged allegiance to al-Qaeda (AQ) or the Islamic State (IS). For example, prominent jihadist groups such as Jama’at al-Tawhid wal-Jihad in Iraq, the Salafist Group for Preaching and Combat in Algeria, al-Shabaab in Somalia, and Jama’at Nusrat al-Islam wal Muslimeen in Mali pledged fidelity to and joined the ranks of al-Qaeda. After declaring its caliphate in June 2014, IS received pledges of allegiance from groups such as Ansar Bayt al-Maqdis in Egypt, Boko Haram in Nigeria, Ahlu Sunna wal Jama’a in Mozambique, and the Bangsamoro Islamic Freedom Fighters in the Philippines¹. Participating in insurgencies across Africa, Asia, and the Middle East, AQ and IS “affiliates”² compete against other armed groups for resources and support in fragmented conflicts.

A growing body of literature examines how competition between armed groups shapes trajectories of violence³. The predominant explanation in existing research suggests that increased competition in violent political markets encourages armed groups to *outbid* rivals by escalating violence—particularly against civilians—to distinguish their “brand”⁴. However, recent scholarship has focused mainly on the proliferation of groups within a conflict and, more recently, infighting between organizations⁵. This focus largely neglects the *type* of actors involved in competition. As a result, conflict research has yet to account for how qualitative changes in violent political markets reshape competitive dynamics and influence the behavior of armed groups.

Building on existing research, this article examines how local armed groups respond to competition from emerging transnational jihadist rivals. In doing so, we argue that the emergence of transnational jihadist groups in a conflict fundamentally reshapes the “rules” of militant competition, making escalatory violence an ineffective and counterproductive strategy for brand differentiation. Rather than engage in outbidding, we contend that armed groups may strategically restrain their use of violence against civilians to distinguish themselves from transnational jihadist actors. This strategic restraint serves a dual purpose: it allows armed groups to appeal to local civilian populations wary of threats of extreme violence posed by transnational jihadists while also bolstering groups’ international reputations. Additionally, we theorize that the use of strategic restraint is most effective under two conditions: first, when armed maintain greater ideological distance from transnational jihadist rivals; and second, when armed groups have credible prospects for improving

¹(Jadoon 2018; Warner et al. 2022)

²Often referred to as “branches” or “franchises,” affiliates constitute jihadist organizations that have pledged allegiance to the leaders of AQ or IS and received formal acceptance into either transnational organization.

³(Bloom 2005; Kydd and Walter 2006; Nemeth 2014; Conrad and Greene 2015; Findley and Young 2012; Phillips 2015; Breslawski and Ives 2019; Conrad and Spaniel 2021a; Belgioioso and Thurber 2024; Polo and Welsh 2024)

⁴(Bloom 2004; Farrell 2020; Asal, Phillips and Rethemeyer 2022)

⁵(Polo and Welsh 2024)

their reputation through restrained behavior.

To test the observable implications of our theory, we analyze novel data on organizational pledges of allegiance to AQ and IS⁶. The data were compiled by examining Arabic and English sources on the organizational histories of 161 jihadist organizations operating in 41 countries. Using Difference-in-Differences (DiD) models, we analyze a time-series cross-sectional dataset covering 485 local armed groups from 2004 to 2016. Using the emergence of these pledges as a quasi-experimental treatment, our design isolates the causal effects of transnational jihadist competition on local group behavior. Our baseline DiD analysis supports the notion that armed groups respond to transnational jihadist competition by reducing violence against civilians. Consistent with our theoretical mechanism, this effect is primarily driven by non-religious and non-terrorist designated groups—those best positioned to signal ideological distance from jihadists and enhance their international reputations through restraint. Notably, we do not observe a similar reduction in attacks against military or police targets, indicating that the restraint is specific to civilian victimization rather than part of a broader decline in violence.

This study contributes to multiple areas of research surrounding armed group behavior and civil war dynamics. Contemporary civil wars are increasingly marked by fragmentation and the presence of numerous armed groups⁷. Quantitative analyses often measure the intensity of militant competition by counting the number of armed groups in a country, assuming that this correlates with a higher propensity for outbidding through escalatory violence. This approach, however, overlooks critical distinctions between the *types* of actors involved in competition. While conventional theories anticipate violent escalation to occur as a consequence of increased competition, our theory of restrained competition demonstrates how, under specific conditions, rivalry between armed groups can incentivize moderation toward civilians. Challenging dominant assumptions about militant behavior in competitive environments, we join recent research that refines outbidding models of escalation⁸.

Second, scholars have explored the different conditions under which organizations may limit violence against civilians. In doing so, key findings have shed light on the importance of factors such as organizational ideology⁹, resource endowments¹⁰, levels of territorial control¹¹, capabili-

⁶We chose to collect original data on pledges rather than relying on Farrell’s (2020) existing dataset. Farrell’s (2020) dataset ends in 2014, excluding the peak period of IS activity, which limits our ability to fully analyze the impact of pledges to IS. In contrast, our dataset includes 27 additional pledges made after 2014—11 to AQ and 16 to IS—providing more comprehensive coverage of recent developments.

⁷(Malone 2022; Lewis 2023)

⁸(Conrad and Spaniel 2021b; Polo and Welsh 2024; Crisman-Cox and Gibilisco 2024)

⁹(Jo 2015; Fazal 2018)

¹⁰(Weinstein 2006)

¹¹(Kalyvas 2006; Holtermann 2019; Oswald et al. 2020)

ties¹², the presence of foreign fighters¹³, and groups' relationship with civilians¹⁴. While existing literature often views competition as a driver of increased violence, we build on this strand of research by highlighting how competition may also lead groups to restrain their violence against civilians under certain circumstances—particularly among non-terrorist designated, non-jihadist groups operating in countries with AQ or IS affiliates, a combination that characterizes a substantial share of armed groups worldwide.

Finally, the transnationalization of armed groups' goals is another defining characteristic of the recent wave of civil wars¹⁵. The rise and “expansion of transnational jihadist groups like IS and al-Qaida and their affiliates represents one of the most distinctive trends in organized violence since the end of the Cold War”¹⁶. To date, scholars have examined why jihadist groups cooperate with AQ and IS and how such links can affect organizational behavior¹⁷. However, relatively less scholarship has explored how high-level cooperation with these transnational organizations affects the behavior of other armed groups in a conflict. Understanding these dynamics remains a pressing concern for scholars and policymakers, as AQ and IS affiliates remain active across multiple regions. Before discussing our theoretical and methodological approach in greater depth, we outline the dynamics surrounding the expansion of AQ and IS over recent years.

Pledging Allegiance to al-Qaeda and the Islamic State

Jihadist organizations—Islamist groups that justify the use of violence to achieve religiously-based goals¹⁸—have proliferated in recent decades. While jihadist involvement characterized only 5 percent of civil wars in the 1990s, this figure rose to 40 percent by 2014¹⁹. This number has continued to increase over time²⁰ As Kalyvas (2018, p. 36) states: “The global spread of a militant or extremist strain of political Islam...ranks as one of the most important political developments in the post–Cold War world.”

Leading the jihadist movement, AQ and IS have played a central role in numerous civil conflicts²¹. To achieve this global influence, AQ and IS “cores” strategically expanded their presence to new geographic areas. One prominent way in which AQ and IS have done so is by collecting

¹²(Wood 2010)

¹³(Doctor and Willingham 2022)

¹⁴(Stanton 2013)

¹⁵(Walter 2017; Svensson and Nilsson 2018; Lynch, Gunning and Valbjørn 2024)

¹⁶(Melander, Pettersson and Themnér 2016, 731)

¹⁷(Farrell 2020; Blair and Potter 2023; Jadoon, Jahanbani and Fruchtman 2023)

¹⁸(Ahmad 2019)

¹⁹(Fearon 2017)

²⁰(Walter 2017)

²¹(Blair and Potter 2023)

formal oaths of allegiance (*bay'a*) from leaders of pre-existing jihadist organizations²². This form of rhetorical cooperation is essential for leaders and their groups to gain formal acceptance into the ranks of AQ or IS²³.

By pledging fealty to the leaders of these transnational organizations, previously unaffiliated groups make a strategic decision that signals their commitment to the ideologies, military strategies, and tactics promoted by AQ or IS²⁴. Once these pledges are recognized by the leadership of AQ or IS, pledging groups assume responsibility for operations in specific geographic regions, such as the “Islamic Maghreb” or “Central Africa.” In many cases, pledging groups espouse new identities and formally abandon previous names in favor of AQ or IS branding, further highlighting their loyalty to AQ or IS²⁵. These alliances are far from symbolic.

This form of militant cooperation has significant implications for the dynamics of conflicts involving pledged groups. For one, AQ, IS, and their affiliates are infamous for their high-casualty attacks and violence against civilians.²⁶ AQ, IS, and their affiliates were involved in more than half of all civil conflicts in 2019, accounting for more than 70 percent of global fatalities caused by armed groups in one-sided violence²⁷. Furthermore, these transnational organizations caused the majority of battle-related deaths in seven out of ten years between 2010 and 2019²⁸. Beyond targeting local civilians and regional regimes, these transnational groups have launched attacks in Europe and the United States as part of their efforts to combat the “Crusader” and “Imperialist” powers²⁹.

Contributing to this violence, AQ played a key role in the global diffusion of suicide attacks³⁰. Organizational affiliates have also frequently employed this tactic. In 2007, the Salafist Group for Preaching and Combat, which changed its name to al-Qaeda in the Islamic Maghreb, executed its first suicide bombing attack just months after pledging fealty to AQ. Al-Qaeda in Iraq, for its part, accounted for a disproportionate percentage of deaths caused by armed groups in Iraq through its use of suicide attacks and indiscriminate violence against civilians³¹.

Similarly, IS attracted worldwide attention for its large-scale violence against civilians. This

²²In some cases, existing AQ members have built organizations from the ground up. For instance, Nasir al-Wuhayshi, who traveled to Afghanistan in the late 1990s and became Osama bin Laden’s personal secretary, built up AQ’s network and conducted attacks in Yemen.

²³(Blair et al. 2022; Berlin 2024; Krause 2024)

²⁴(Brzezinski 2024)

²⁵(Byman 2014)

²⁶This is not to say that these groups do not place any limits on their violence or only target civilian populations in organizational operations. Recent years have witnessed various attempts by AQ and its affiliates to limit Muslim casualties in attacks (Hamming 2020).

²⁷(Pettersson and Öberg 2020)

²⁸(Pettersson and Öberg 2020)

²⁹(Hegghammer 2009)

³⁰(Moghadam 2009)

³¹(Piazza 2009)

involved massacres, sexual violence, videotaped executions, beheadings, burning and drowning of hostages, and crushing captives with tanks³². Jihadist groups that pledged their allegiance to IS have also emulated the latter’s brutality and mass casualty attacks³³. In 2020, IS’s affiliate in Mozambique turned a football pitch into an “execution ground,” beheading more than 50 people³⁴. Ansar Bayt al-Maqdis, which pledged to IS in 2014, claimed responsibility for the 2015 downing of Metrojet Flight 9268, killing 224 passengers. The Islamic State Khorasan’s 2021 suicide bombing attack at the Kabul Airport, which killed 170 civilians and 13 U.S. soldiers, is noted to have “sent shockwaves around the world”³⁵.

Overall, AQ, IS, and their affiliates are often associated with a legacy of brutality against civilians, significant international scrutiny and media attention, and conflict with global powers. In the following sections, we explore how and why these dynamics can affect militant competition.

Competition and Escalation in the Shadow of Transnational Jihadists

Contemporary civil conflicts are increasingly fragmented, forcing armed groups to compete against each other for scarce resources and support³⁶. Since civilian populations can provide armed groups with sustenance, shelter, recruitment, and intelligence³⁷, securing a degree of civilian support is vital to group survival. As an Irish militant aptly asserted, “No guerrilla can exist without a support base”³⁸. However, in highly competitive conflict environments, civilians often remain ambivalent about the true intentions and capabilities of rival groups, making it difficult for individual groups to secure popular support at the expense of their rivals³⁹. To overcome this uncertainty, armed groups can calibrate their use of violence, selecting from a variety of violent tactics to project strength, credibility, and commitment to their cause.

According to conventional scholarly wisdom, one prominent strategy through which armed groups calibrate their violence to increase their “market share” of popular support is through *violent outbidding*⁴⁰. Violent outbidding involves the deliberate adoption of increasingly innovative and severe tactics to distinguish one’s organization from rival groups by signaling greater resolve

³²(Friis 2018)

³³(Brzezinski 2024)

³⁴(BBC 2020)

³⁵(Ghazaleh, Kepel and Milelli 2008, 2)

³⁶(Gade, Hafez and Gabbay 2019)

³⁷(Crenshaw 1987; Balcells and Stanton 2021)

³⁸(Okado-Gough 2003)

³⁹(Kydd and Walter 2006)

⁴⁰(Bloom 2004)

and effectiveness to potential supporters⁴¹. As Conrad and Greene (2015, p. 549) state: “While committing more shocking attacks may not...help the group achieve long-term goals, the spectacle of more severe attacks might generate the *perception* that the organization is more effective than it actually is.”

The outbidding model of violence—described as “one of the most widely cited theories of [armed] groups’ motivations and actions”⁴²—has been frequently used to explain the use of various tactics and targeting strategies by armed groups. For example, scholars have focused on the consequences of militant competition to explain the proliferation of suicide bombings and attacks against NGOs, schools, sexual minorities, and U.S. citizens abroad⁴³. Increased competition has also been found to be a driver of violence against civilians⁴⁴. However, empirical tests of outbidding’s theoretical expectations have yielded mixed results⁴⁵. Inconsistent evidence of violent escalation has cast doubt on the universality of outbidding as an outcome of militant competition, suggesting that the incentives for armed groups to escalate violence may be contingent on specific contextual conditions.

Recent formal modeling innovations insinuate that one such condition may be the initial level of violence used by competing groups⁴⁶. For outbidding to be an effective signaling mechanism, competing armed groups may need to start from a relatively moderate stance regarding the use of extreme violence. This initial moderation establishes a baseline from which groups can escalate their tactics in response to rivals’ actions, creating opportunities for differentiation through increased brutality. Under such conditions, each incremental act of violence can serve as a strategic signal of commitment and capability, helping groups develop distinct identities within a violent political market.

In contrast, if rival organizations already employ extreme violence from the outset, the potential for meaningful escalation may be limited, potentially reducing the effectiveness of the outbidding mechanism⁴⁷. In these cases, armed groups may recognize that they cannot match the capabilities or effectiveness of their rivals to change public opinion through violence⁴⁸. In addition, escalating violence can lead to condemnation from members of the international community. Adopting extreme tactics risks drawing significant levels of external scrutiny, such as in the form of official terrorist designations. Rather than improving chances of survival, attempts to outbid can instead

⁴¹(Kydd and Walter 2006; Belgioioso 2018; Conrad and Spaniel 2021a)

⁴²(Farrell 2020, p. 437)

⁴³(Bloom 2005; Murdie and Stapley 2014; Tschantret 2018; Biberman and Zahid 2019; Asal, Phillips and Rethemeyer 2022; Asal et al. 2023; Conrad, Greene and Phillips 2023)

⁴⁴(Wood and Kathman 2015)

⁴⁵(Findley and Young 2012; Stanton 2013)

⁴⁶For instance, Crisman-Cox and Gibilisco (2024) show that the escalatory effects of competition are most likely to occur when groups’ competitive positions are relatively balanced.

⁴⁷(Polo and Welsh 2024)

⁴⁸(Crisman-Cox and Gibilisco 2024)

erode the legitimacy of local groups, invite external sanctions and repression, and jeopardize their long-term viability.

These dynamics highlight the ways in which the spread of AQ and IS to different conflict zones through their affiliates can reshape the “rules” of militant competition. By establishing a baseline for extreme violence, AQ and IS affiliates raise the threshold for escalation to a level that renders further increases in violence ineffective as a means of differentiation. As a result, the presence of transnational jihadist competitors may compel local groups to explore more effective ways of distinguishing themselves. Moreover, transnational jihadists often provoke scrutiny from global actors and, at times, external state intervention. These external pressures impose significant reputational and strategic risks that local groups must navigate to maintain their reputations. Confronted with these challenges, local groups might feel pressure to avoid escalatory violence as a branding strategy and compete through other forms of behavior.

Restrained Competition

An expanding body of literature demonstrates that armed groups may deliberately restrain their use of violence, even when they possess the capability to do otherwise. Busher and Bjørge (2020, p. 3) define restraint as a conscious process in which “militants *choose* to drop, downscale, or limit an attack or campaign, or adopt tactical or strategic innovations that lead them away from violence.” Such decisions often reflect recognition that certain forms of violence may be strategically counterproductive to securing popular support, misaligned with group identities, or harmful to organizational survival⁴⁹.

In this section, we develop our theory of *restrained competition*. Restraining violence against civilians can constitute an intentional strategy adopted by armed groups⁵⁰. Here, restrained competition denotes a strategy in which armed groups reduce violence against civilians to differentiate themselves from transnational jihadist rivals. We argue that outbidding becomes ineffective and potentially counterproductive when local armed groups face transnational jihadists already associated with extreme brutality and international scrutiny. Building on the premise that the *type* of rival an armed group faces shapes militant competition, we contend that competition from highly stigmatized transnational jihadist groups incentivizes local groups to moderate their behavior to appeal to both domestic civilian populations and international actors.

⁴⁹(Busher and Bjørge 2020; Macklin 2020)

⁵⁰(Balcells and Stanton 2021; Onder 2024)

Restraint as Differentiation

When the conditions necessary for outbidding to be effective are lacking, armed groups can pursue alternative differentiation strategies to maintain their competitiveness. One such strategy involves limiting civilian targeting. Restraint against civilians can serve as a deliberate tactic to preserve local support and maintain political viability⁵¹. By restraining their violence against civilians, armed groups can position themselves as a moderate alternative to extremist actors, presenting themselves as a more locally grounded and community-oriented alternative⁵². Limiting violence against civilians may further allow armed groups to increase support among populations outside of their zones of influence⁵³.

Restraining violence against civilians can also allow armed groups to avoid public backlash. After all, attacks against civilians are among the most consequential forms of violence used by armed groups, with violence against civilians carrying substantial reputational risks for armed groups⁵⁴. As Polo (2020, 236) observes: “Terrorist attacks against undefended civilians...can be much more costly than attacks on official targets in terms of loss of popular support and legitimacy.” Various examples highlight how groups active in different contexts have sought to appeal to local support bases while avoiding costs associated with civilian targeting. For example, the Frente Farabundo Martí para la Liberación Nacional in El Salvador recognized the reputational costs of civilian victimization and, by the mid-1980s, shifted its focus to infrastructure targets rather than high-casualty attacks on civilians⁵⁵. Similarly, both the Euskadi Ta Askatasuna and Irish Republican Army transitioned away from indiscriminate civilian killings as they responded to the increasingly moderate preferences of their support bases⁵⁶.

The ability to cultivate legitimacy and avoid backlash through restraint against civilians operates not only locally but also on the international stage. Recent research demonstrates that armed groups may calibrate their violence in anticipation of external support⁵⁷. In addition to contrasting their violence with that of regimes to win international support, armed groups may also seek to differentiate themselves from local competitors to win international favor⁵⁸. As Tokdemir and co-authors (2021, 737) write: “Moderate groups are more likely to engender international sympathy and support, which can bring external patrons, support from diasporas, and donations to the group’s cause.” Restraining violence against civilians is one way in which armed groups can present them-

⁵¹(Balcells and Stanton 2021)

⁵²(Berlin and Rangazas 2023)

⁵³(De la Calle 2017)

⁵⁴(Conrad and Greene 2015; Polo 2020; El Masri and Phillips 2024)

⁵⁵(Stanton 2013)

⁵⁶(Sanchez-Cuenca 2007)

⁵⁷(Levy, Dudley and Siegel 2024)

⁵⁸(Stanton 2020)

selves as relatively moderate compared to other groups in a conflict zone. As Fazal states: (2018, 197) “Restrained groups are disciplined groups, and disciplined groups are generally preferred by third parties as partners. Thus, by refraining from targeting civilians,” armed groups can “send signals to the international community of their willingness and capacity to be good citizens of that community.”

On the international stage, restraint can operate both defensively—to avoid stigmatization and punitive intervention—and offensively—as a tool to attract external support and recognition. Demonstrated restraint towards civilians can be particularly effective in securing support from democratic sponsors who tend to be more sensitive to human rights abuses than authoritarian regimes⁵⁹, or when local groups can contrast their restraint with the brutality of transnational jihadists⁶⁰. This dynamic occurred in Syria, where Kurdish armed groups secured higher levels of external support by distinguishing themselves from the ideological extremism of IS⁶¹. Furthermore, groups that avoid indiscriminate violence against civilians can more effectively shield themselves from international condemnation, including naming-and-shaming campaigns⁶² and punitive interventions such as sanctions from the United Nations and International Criminal Court prosecutions⁶³. On the international legal scene, Jo (2015, 115) notes that, “rebel groups are increasingly under pressure from international law”.

Together, these insights highlight how restrained competition offers armed groups an alternative pathway to differentiation. Transnational jihadist rivals can escalate violence to extreme levels in competitive violent markets. This leaves little room for additional escalation to occur without alienating local populations, provoking international backlash, or attracting punitive measures from external actors. Restraining violence against civilians allows armed groups to navigate competitive pressures while preserving and potentially strengthening their local support and international appeal. In doing so, armed groups can cultivate a positive reputation among multiple audiences—projecting an image of accountability that contrasts with the violence used by AQ and IS. Due to these dynamics, we argue that:

Hypothesis 1. Armed groups facing competition from a transnational jihadist rival will reduce violence against civilians.

⁵⁹(Salehyan, Siroky and Wood 2014)

⁶⁰(Stanton 2020)

⁶¹(Schwab 2023)

⁶²(Brandt and Kotajoki 2023)

⁶³(Jo and Simmons 2016)

Ideological Distance and the Incentives for Restraint

Building on our restrained competition argument—that restraint enables local armed groups to position themselves as viable alternatives to transnational jihadist organizations both locally and internationally—we argue that the incentives for restraint are not uniform across all armed groups. Instead, these incentives may vary according to a group’s ideological distance from transnational jihadist rivals. An ideology denotes “a set of more or less systematic ideas that identify a constituency, the objectives pursued on behalf of that group, and a program of action”⁶⁴. In contemporary conflicts, ideology “shapes relations between members of a group and outsiders”⁶⁵. As such, ideology functions as both a guiding framework for action and a symbolic marker that distinguishes armed groups from their competitors within violent political markets.

Armed groups that share ideological affinities with transnational jihadist rivals may struggle to construct meaningful contrasts with those rivals. Similar doctrinal justifications for violence, overlapping constituencies, or common enemy hierarchies may render these groups indistinguishable to local and international observers. For example, some U.S. policymakers and analysts continue to view “radical Islam” as a monolithic movement, seeing little distinction between disparate Islamist groups despite their adoption of significantly different goals, strategies, and tactics⁶⁶.

In contrast, armed groups with greater ideological distance from transnational jihadist groups—whether in terms of conflict framing, visions of governance, or territorial aspirations⁶⁷—can more effectively leverage restrained behavior to highlight their differences from these rivals. This sharper ideological contrast allows groups to signal not only their rejection of brutal and indiscriminate tactics but also their broader disassociation from the radical worldviews that justify such violence. For instance, armed groups with secular nationalist, secessionist, or Marxist revolutionary agendas—which the literature consistently links to aspirations for state-building within recognized borders, social transformation through service provision, and international recognition through modulated behavior⁶⁸—may employ restraint when competing against transnational jihadists. In doing so, these groups can contrast themselves with organizations that have a history of mass violence against civilians and that are focused on overturning the existing international order.

Ideological distance from transnational jihadists can therefore amplify the credibility of restraint as a signal to local and external audiences, helping restraint to be interpreted not merely as a tactical adjustment, but as a principled stance. Unlike groups with overlapping religious narratives that may struggle to convince observers of their meaningful differences from transnational

⁶⁴(Sanín and Wood 2014, 213)

⁶⁵(Ugarriza and Matthew 2013, 450)

⁶⁶(Lynch 2017)

⁶⁷(Gade, Hafez and Gabbay 2019)

⁶⁸(Stewart 2018; Fazal 2021; Huang and Sullivan 2021)

jihadists, ideologically distinct groups can leverage restraint to project a consistent image. Based on this discussion, we contend that:

Hypothesis 2. Armed groups that are *ideologically distant* from transnational jihadist rivals will *reduce* violence against civilians *more* than groups that share ideological affinities with these organizations.

Prospects for Reputational Gain and the Incentives for Restraint

Although ideological distance from transnational jihadists enhances the credibility of restraint as a signal, not all groups are equally positioned to translate this credibility into reputational gains—particularly on the international stage. The potential to bolster international appeal through restraint likely depends on how key audiences perceive groups. As a result, an armed group’s pre-existing reputation can further shape the incentives for adopting restraint as a competitive strategy.

Here, pre-existing reputation refers to how an armed group is perceived by external actors, including foreign governments, international organizations, and advocacy networks, before it adopts or rejects restraint as a strategy. This reputation is often reflected in formal diplomatic recognition, prior participation in or exclusion from peace processes, and classifications such as terrorist lists and sanctions, which codify external perceptions of a group’s legitimacy or threat level. Among these indicators, terrorist designations stand out as particularly powerful markers of a group’s reputation. The “terrorist” label codifies perceptions of a group as illegitimate and threatening, institutionalizing this negative reputation through legal and economic restrictions⁶⁹.

Terrorist designations, particularly those issued by the United States, carry far-reaching consequences that can sharpen or blunt incentives for restraint. The role of the United States as a global leader in counterterrorism and national security means that its designations influence the positions of other governments toward armed groups⁷⁰. Once a group is labeled a terrorist organization, it becomes subject to economic sanctions, asset freezes, and travel restrictions, limiting its political and operational flexibility⁷¹. These labels often lead to greater isolation, limiting access to international aid, diplomatic channels, and negotiation opportunities⁷². This reputational damage can be irreparable given the long-lasting nature of terrorist designations⁷³.

Although jihadist organizations are found to be more likely to be designated as terrorists by the United States, this stigma is not limited to religious organizations⁷⁴. Prominent secessionist and

⁶⁹(Búzás and Meier 2023)

⁷⁰(El Masri and Phillips 2024)

⁷¹(Cronin 2004; Haspelslagh 2013; Jo, Phillips and Alley 2020; Tominaga, Lee and Lyu 2022)

⁷²(Haspelslagh 2021)

⁷³(Phillips 2019)

⁷⁴(El Masri and Phillips 2024)

Marxist revolutionary groups, such as the Shining Path in Peru, the PKK in Turkey, LTTE in Sri Lanka, CIRA in the UK have also been blacklisted. This highlights that even groups with localized ambitions and secular state-building objectives may be burdened by the stigma of negative prior reputations.

Overall, we argue that armed groups that have thus far avoided blacklisting by terrorist designation are better positioned to leverage strategic restraint as a tool for enhancing their international appeal. Their relatively untainted reputations leave open the possibility of building legitimacy in the eyes of international actors. In contrast, groups already burdened by terrorist designations face significant constraints in translating restraint into reputational gains. As a result, the strategic effectiveness of restrained competition can depend on a group's reputational starting point and its prospects for reshaping external perceptions. Thus, when facing competition from transnational jihadist rivals, we posit:

Hypothesis 3. Armed groups *without prior terrorist designations* will *reduce* violence against civilians *more* than armed groups already designated as terrorists.

Data and Research Design

We exploit pledges of allegiance to AQ and IS by jihadist organizations as a quasi-experimental treatment within a Difference-in-Differences (DiD) framework. This allows us to assess how armed groups adapt their behavior in response to the abrupt onset of competition from transnational jihadists in the form of AQ and IS affiliates.

Our DiD models draw on a time-series cross-sectional dataset of 485 armed groups from 2004 to 2016, drawn from the Extended Data on Terrorist Groups (EDTG) dataset⁷⁵. We do not use the UCDP/PRIO Armed Conflict Dataset, which applies a 25 battle-related deaths per year threshold to define conflict. This criterion would introduce selection bias into our analysis by disproportionately omitting less violent groups. In contrast, the EDTG dataset provides broader coverage by incorporating groups listed in the Global Terrorism Database (GTD), regardless of their violence levels. This inclusive approach better aligns with our objective of examining whether various types of armed groups reduce violence against civilians. The analysis begins in 2004, the year of the first pledge to AQ by a non-affiliated group⁷⁶. Pledging remained rare through the 2000s—with only one additional case in 2006, none in 2007-2008, and only two in 2009—allowing us to establish a clear behavioral baseline for rival armed groups.

⁷⁵(Hou, Gaibullov and Sandler 2020)

⁷⁶(Byman 2014; Mendelsohn 2015)

Civilian Victimization

Our primary outcome is civilian victimization by armed groups that have not pledged allegiance to AQ or IS (hereafter, “non-AQ/IS-affiliated groups”). We examine changes in these groups’ violence against civilians following pledges of allegiance to AQ or IS by jihadist groups operating in the same country.

We measure civilian victimization using incident-level data from the GTD, which categorizes 22 target/victim types. We classify attacks as civilian victimization if the GTD lists targets as private citizens, businesses, educational institutions, journalists, religious figures, tourists, NGOs, airports, maritime, telecommunications, transportation systems, or abortion clinics⁷⁷. Our primary measure, *Civilian Victimization*, counts the number of such attacks by a non-AQ/IS-affiliated group in a given year⁷⁸. We also report robustness checks using *Number of Civilian Casualties*, *Casualties per Attack Targeting Civilians*, and negative binomial models with the count of attacks (see appendix).

Pledges to al-Qaeda and Islamic State

We collected data on pledges to AQ and IS by analyzing the organizational histories of 161 jihadist groups active at some point between 2004 and 2019 across 41 countries in Central Asia, the Middle East and North Africa, South and Southeast Asia, and sub-Saharan Africa. We first compiled a list of jihadist organizations⁷⁹ by reviewing armed groups in the Armed Group Dataset⁸⁰, Non-State Actors in Armed Conflict Dataset (NSA)⁸¹, Big, Allied and Dangerous (BAAD)⁸², How Terrorist Groups End⁸³, and the Mapping Militants Project⁸⁴. We supplemented these with scholarly publications, policy reports, and media sources, as many existing datasets predate the rise of IS and often lack reliable information on groups’ relationships with AQ/IS.

For each group, we identified formal pledges of “allegiance,” “fealty,” or “fidelity” to AQ or IS⁸⁵. We focus on pledges from previously unaffiliated groups to AQ or IS. This focus helps to isolate the disruptive impact of spontaneous affiliation with AQ/IS causally⁸⁶, avoiding endo-

⁷⁷We exclude attacks on government, police, military, and violent organizations.

⁷⁸We log this variable after adding 1 to address zero values, following standard practice.

⁷⁹We excluded Shi’a groups, which may also pursue jihadist goals, because they do not pledge allegiance to AQ or IS.

⁸⁰(Malone 2022)

⁸¹(Cunningham, Gleditsch and Salehyan 2013)

⁸²(Asal and Rethemeyer 2015)

⁸³(Jones and Libicki 2008)

⁸⁴(Crenshaw 2010)

⁸⁵We exclude pledges by individuals and cases of temporary logistical cooperation, focusing solely on organizational-level pledges, which are the main mechanism for AQ and IS expansion.

⁸⁶We discuss the plausible randomness of pledges by pre-existing groups in greater detail as we consider the parallel trends assumption below.

geneity that might be introduced by centrally planned expansions by AQ/IS. We also omit cases of broad ideological support that lack declarations of allegiance, since formal pledges are required for integration into AQ or IS networks⁸⁷. Arabic-language media and jihadist communiqués helped us distinguish between different types of connections among jihadist actors.

For each pledge, we recorded the year and the group’s main area of operation. Figure 1 illustrates the geographic distribution of these pledges, highlighting their relevance across diverse conflicts and the broader study of civilian victimization. The map also shows that many countries with active armed groups lack such pledges, enabling empirical comparisons between contexts with and without transnational jihadist competition.

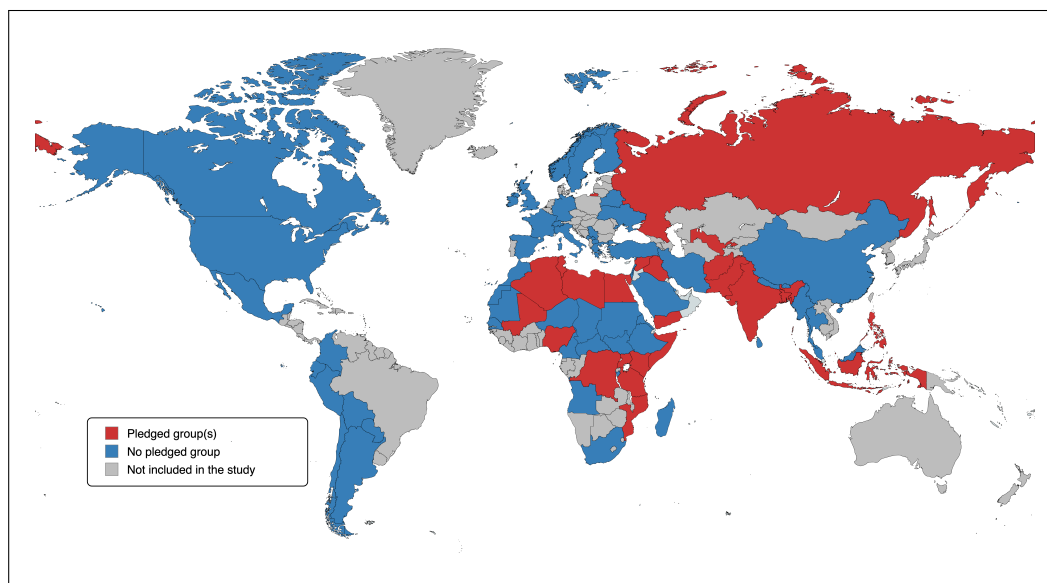


Figure 1. Geographic Distribution of Pledges to AQ and IS, 2004-2016

Ideology and Terrorist Designation

Religious ideology is a key dimension for capturing ideological distance between non-AQ/IS-affiliated groups and their transnational jihadist competitors. Using the EDTG, we code *religious group ideology* as a binary variable, classifying groups as either religiously motivated or not. While this approach cannot capture ideological shifts—such as instances where jihadist groups adopt secular rhetoric amid changing military conditions⁸⁸—it remains the most feasible given our dataset’s cross-national scope. Moreover, the broad distinction between religious and secular ideologies aligns with our theoretical interest in ideological distance⁸⁹.

⁸⁷(Blair et al. 2022; Berlin 2024)

⁸⁸(Ying 2024)

⁸⁹The EDTG classifies a group as religious if it espouses a religious fundamentalist ideology, excluding those that invoke religion solely as part of ethnic identity. Although the measure includes non-Islamist religious groups, only

We measure *terrorist designation* using the U.S. Department of State’s Foreign Terrorist Organization (FTO) list⁹⁰, coding groups as designated or not. We focus on U.S. designations given that numerous countries follow the policies of the United States in their designating armed groups as terrorists⁹¹.

Difference-in-Differences Design

We use a DiD design to assess how pledges to AQ or IS affect the civilian victimization behavior of non-AQ/IS-affiliated groups operating in the same country. Our analysis is conducted at the group-year level to more precisely capture group behavior.

Pledges serve as the treatment. We compare average changes in civilian victimization over time among treated groups (those in countries with pledges) and control groups (those in countries without pledges). While groups in pledge-affected countries may differ systematically from those in unaffected countries, the DiD design allows us to identify within-group changes over time, controlling for time-invariant group-level characteristics and time-variant confounders that apply uniformly across groups. Figure 2 displays the geographic distribution of treated groups.

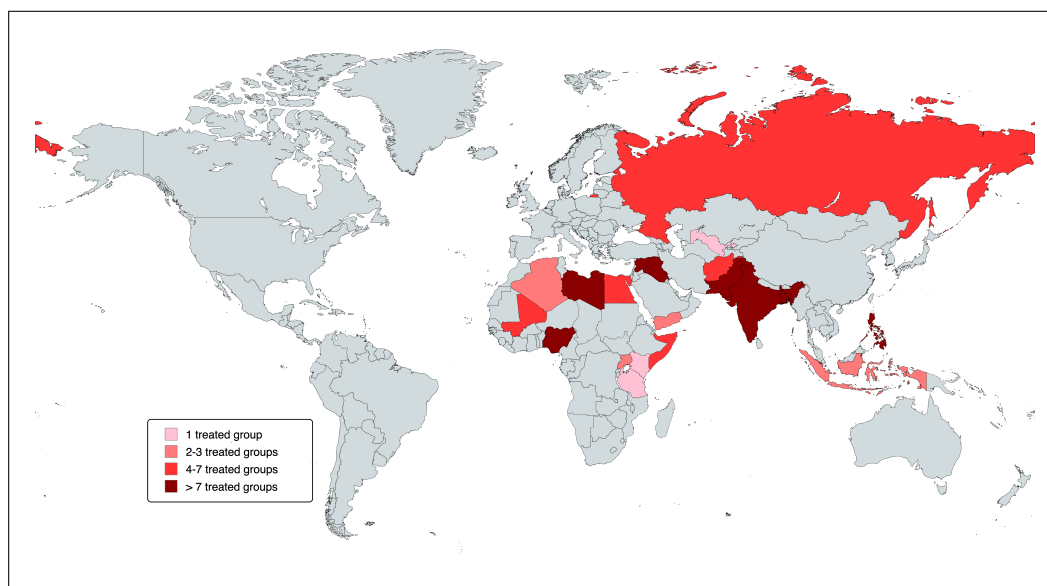


Figure 2. Geographic Distribution of Treated Groups, 2004-2016

Because pledges occur in different years, we employ a staggered DiD design, which accommo-

six appear in our 2004–2016 sample: Bodu Bala Sena (Buddhist), Anti-Balaka (Christian), Lord’s Resistance Army (Christian), Jewish Defense League, Kach, and Kahane Chai (Jewish). As a robustness check, we recoded these groups as ideologically distant from AQ and IS affiliates and reran our subsample analyses. As shown in the Appendix, the results remain substantively unchanged.

⁹⁰See: <https://www.state.gov/foreign-terrorist-organizations/>

⁹¹(El Masri and Phillips 2024)

dates variation in treatment timing across groups. Unlike standard DiD methods such as Two-Way Fixed Effects (TWFE), this approach estimates dynamic treatment effects and avoids bias from heterogeneous treatment timing⁹². Figure 3 shows the annual number of newly treated groups, with 2014—coinciding with IS’s peak—marking the highest number of new treated groups (e.g., groups in countries a pledge to AQ or IS)..

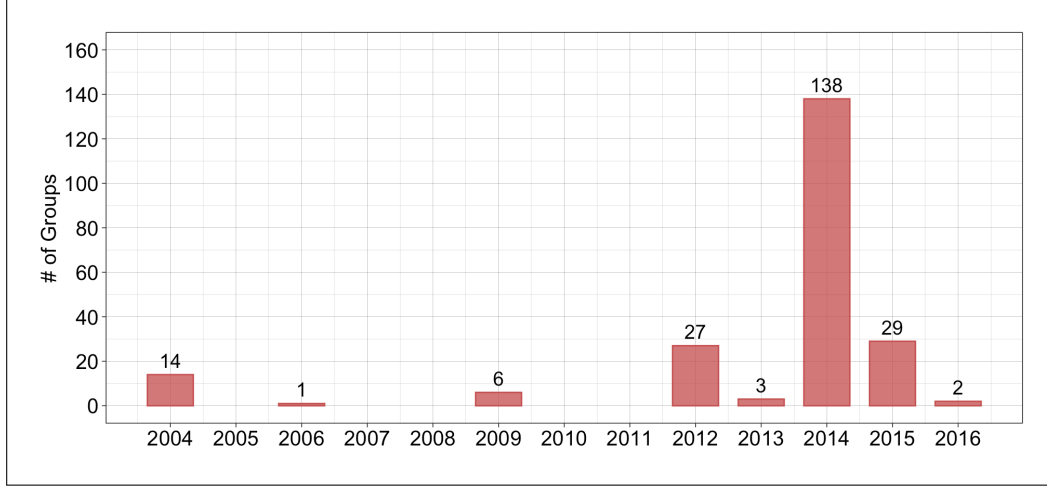


Figure 3. Number of Groups Treated Each Year, 2004-2016

We estimate the effects of pledges on civilian victimization outcomes using the following DiD model:

$$Y_{it} = \alpha + \beta \text{Treatment}_{it} + \delta_t + \lambda_i + \varepsilon_{it} \quad (1)$$

where Y_{it} denotes the outcome variable (e.g., civilian victimization by non-AQ/IS-affiliated group) for group i at time t . The term α represents the intercept. The treatment indicator Treatment_{it} is equal to 1 if group i is operating in a country with a pledged group at time t and from then onwards, and 0 otherwise. Time fixed effects are denoted by δ_t , capturing factors that vary over time but are constant across units. Unit fixed effects are represented by λ_i , accounting for characteristics that vary between non-AQ/IS-affiliated groups but are constant over time. ε_{it} represents the error term, which includes all other unobserved factors.

In extended models, we add time-varying controls: the group’s share of transnational attacks, attack diversity, binary indicators for kidnapping/extortion or leadership decapitation, and group age. Details on these controls appear in the Appendix.

⁹²(Callaway and Sant’Anna 2021)

Parallel Trends

A core assumption of the DiD strategy is parallel trends: absent treatment (i.e., pledges), the average change in civilian victimization among treated groups would have mirrored that of control groups. If this holds, the model can isolate the treatment effect on outcome from confounders that influence both pledging and civilian targeting. This assumption might be compromised if country-level confounders affect both the likelihood of jihadist groups pledging and the manner in which non-AQ/IS-affiliated groups victimize civilians. We assess this assumption both theoretically and empirically.

The assumption is likely to hold in our context because pledging decisions are primarily shaped by leader- or group-level dynamics rather than country-level factors. Pledges are geographically dispersed⁹³, and prior research identifies intra-organizational strife and reputational deficits of particular leaders—not national context—as key drivers of pledging⁹⁴.

A potential concern is that pledges are endogenously driven by domestic militant competition over resources, which might also influence civilian victimization. Yet many groups operating in highly competitive environments—e.g., Ajnad Misr, Ansar al-Shari’a Libya, Islamic Jihad Union, Moro Islamic Liberation Front, and Tehrik-e-Taliban Pakistan—never pledged to AQ or IS. Others, like the Salafist Group for Preaching and Combat in Algeria and the Islamic Movement of Uzbekistan, pledged years after competition with rivals had started⁹⁵. Although this concern surrounding competition warrants consideration, it does not undermine the validity of our estimates. If pledges were primarily a response to escalating domestic competition, and if such competition increased civilian targeting, we would expect pledges to correlate with higher, not lower, victimization by non-AQ/IS-affiliate groups. Our results, however, show the opposite pattern.

To further assess the robustness of our DiD design, we empirically examine the parallel trends assumption⁹⁶. First, we test for pre-treatment trends by comparing civilian victimization rates between treated and control groups before the treatment. Parallel trends plots in the Appendix show that the trends were approximately parallel during this period. Second, we conduct a pre-treatment regression analysis by interacting the DiD treatment variable with time dummies to create *leads* (e.g., dummy variables for pre-treatment periods) and *lags* (e.g., dummy variables for post-treatment periods)⁹⁷. Using the following equation:

⁹³(Blair and Potter 2023)

⁹⁴(Byman 2014; Mendelsohn 2015; Bacon 2018; Blair and Potter 2023; Berlin 2024)

⁹⁵(Berlin 2024)

⁹⁶While standard methods exist for evaluating parallel trends, none can definitively confirm it. These tests offer suggestive, not conclusive, evidence (Huntington-Klein 2022).

⁹⁷(Autor 2003)

$$Y_{it} = \alpha + \sum_{k=-m}^{-1} \beta_k(\text{Time}_{t+k} \times \text{Treatment}_i) + \sum_{k=1}^n \gamma_k(\text{Time}_{t+k} \times \text{Treatment}_i) + \delta_t + \lambda_i + \varepsilon_{it} \quad (2)$$

where Y_{it} is the outcome variable, Time_{t+k} represents the time dummies, and Treatment_i is the treatment indicator, we test whether the pre-treatment trends for the treatment and control groups are parallel. If parallel trends hold, the interaction terms for the *leads* (β_k) should be statistically insignificant—which is what we observe (see Appendix).

Finally, we use event-study models to further probe pre-treatment imbalances⁹⁸. As shown in Figures 4–6, we find no statistically significant differences between treatment and control groups, lending additional support to the parallel trends assumption.

Testing for Heterogeneous Treatment Effects

We extend our DiD analysis to test Hypotheses 2 and 3, which assess whether the effects of transnational jihadist competition vary by local groups’ ideological orientation and prior terrorist designation. To do so, we apply the original staggered DiD model to relevant subpopulations.

For Hypothesis 2, we divide the sample into religious and non-religious groups based on ideological profiles and estimate the DiD model separately for each. We expect larger reductions in civilian victimization among non-religious groups and weaker or null effects among religious groups. For Hypothesis 3, we classify groups by their terrorist designation status prior to treatment and again estimate the model within each subset. We anticipate greater reductions among non-designated groups compared to designated ones.

Results

We estimate the average treatment effects in our DiD setup, with *Pledges* serving as the treatment and *Civilian Victimization* by non-AQ/IS-affiliated groups (measured as the logged number of attacks against civilians) being the dependent variable. We use clustered bootstrapped standard errors at the group level.

Baseline Results

Our first set of results evaluates the effect of pledges in a country on the civilian victimization strategies of non-AQ/IS-affiliated groups operating in the same country using the full sample of

⁹⁸(Hassell and Holbein 2024)

groups. Table 1 presents the weighted average of group-time average treatment effects. Model 1 provides a naive estimate of the treatment effect, while Model 2 introduces controls for targeting strategies that may influence victimization patterns. Model 3 also accounts for leader decapitation and group age.

Across all specifications, non-AQ/IS-affiliated groups exhibit restraint toward civilians following pledges. The Average Treatment Effect (ATE) of pledges on civilian victimization is consistently negative and statistically significant at the 90% confidence level across models. Estimates from the fully specified Model 3 suggest that pledges caused a 16.31% decrease in the expected number of attacks targeting civilians.

These findings align with expectations, suggesting pledges correspond to a reduction civilian victimization. However, the results' significance at the 90% confidence level warrants a cautious interpretation, offering moderate—though not definitive—support for the restraint hypothesis (H1) when applying DiD models to the entire sample without accounting for group ideology or designation status.

Table 1. Pledges and Local Groups' Civilian Victimization

<i>DV: Civilian Victimization</i>			
Sample: All non-AQ/IS-Affiliated Groups			
	Model 1	Model 2	Model 3
Average Treatment Effect	-0.1754* (0.0965)	-0.1599* (0.0947)	-0.1781* (0.0952)
Time-Fixed Effects	Yes	Yes	Yes
Unit-Fixed Effects	Yes	Yes	Yes
<i>Controls</i>			
Share of Transnational Attacks	No	Yes	Yes
Diversity of Attacks	No	Yes	Yes
Kidnapping/Extortion	No	Yes	Yes
Leader Decapitation	No	No	Yes
Group Age (logged)	No	No	Yes
N	2366	2301	2301

Note 1: **p < 0.05, *p < 0.1

Note 2: Robust standard errors clustered on group are in parentheses. All models are estimated with Callaway and Sant'Anna's (2021) doubly robust estimation method for staggered Difference-in-Differences using the `att_gt` function of the `did` package in R. All models consider both "Never Treated" and "Not Yet Treated" units as the control group.

Further insights emerge from the event study analysis reported in Figure 4. Event time refers to the years before and after the announcement of pledges. Negative values of event time denote pre-

treatment periods, whereas positive values denote the post-treatment period. Dynamic group-time average treatment effects⁹⁹ reveal no significant differences between treatment and control units in the pre-treatment period, confirming parallel trends.

Post-treatment estimates show a downward shift in civilian victimization. While some estimates achieve only 90% confidence (red markers), others reach 95% (blue markers). Notably, years 5, 6, and 9 post-treatment exhibit substantial reductions in civilian targeting. These patterns reinforce the hypothesis that transnational extremist competition encourages restraint among local non-AQ/IS-affiliated groups, albeit with modest overall effects.

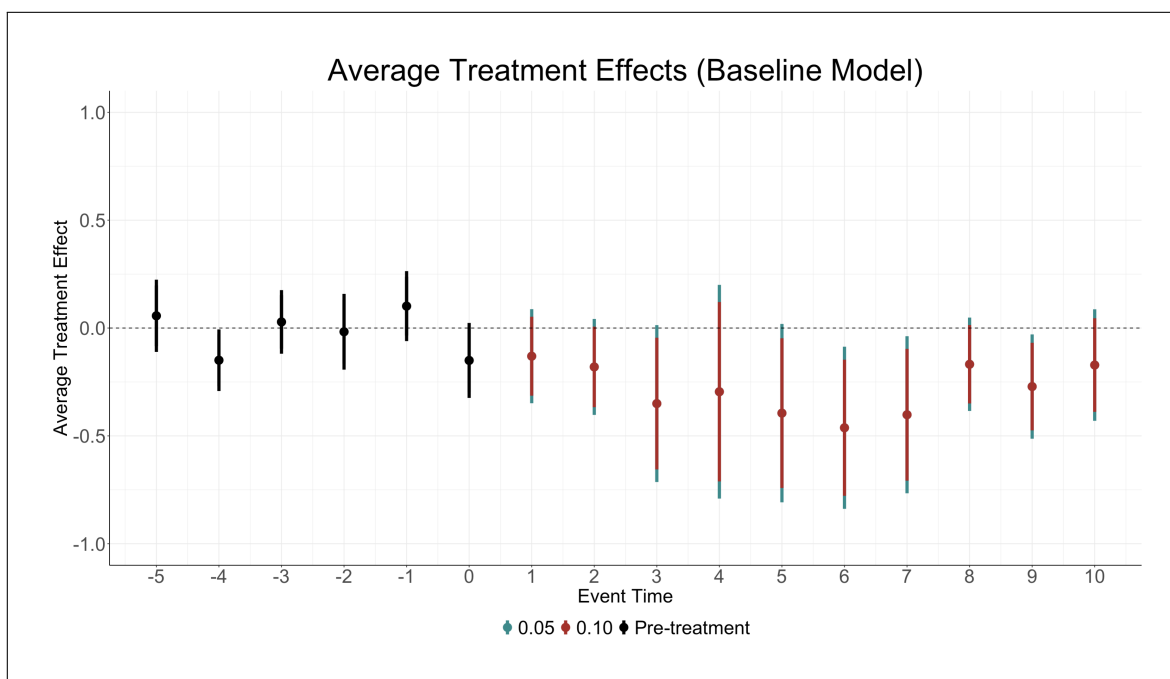


Figure 4. Aggregate Group-Time Average Treatment Effects (Event Study), 2004-2016
Note: Event study is based on Model 1 of Table 1. Dynamic group-time average treatment effects are computed using the `aggte` function of the `did` package in R.

Heterogeneous Treatment Effects by Ideology

We next examine the effects of pledges on civilian victimization by non-AQ/IS-affiliated local groups by disaggregating groups based on ideology—religious versus non-religious—to evaluate whether ideological distance between non-AQ/IS-affiliated groups and transnational jihadists moderates responses to competition (H2).

Separate DiD models are run for religious (N = 136) and non-religious groups (N = 349). Table 2 presents these results. Religious groups show no evidence of restraint, yet their ATEs (Models

⁹⁹This procedure computes average effects across varying lengths of treatment exposure and mirrors an event study approach.

4–6) are consistently negative, albeit statistically insignificant. Importantly, these results also fail to support the conventional outbidding hypothesis, suggesting that religious groups do not escalate civilian targeting in response to competition with AQ and IS affiliates.

In contrast, non-religious groups (Models 7–9) show stronger support for both the overall restraint hypothesis (H1) and the *ideological distance* hypothesis (H2). The ATEs are negative and significant at the 95% confidence level in Model 7 and the 90% level in Models 8 and 9. Although the 90% threshold reflects a modest level of statistical significance, the consistency and direction of the effects in all models provide suggestive evidence that ideological distance from transnational jihadist actors conditions how local groups adapt their strategies. Estimates from the fully specified Model 9 indicate pledges reduced non-religious non-AQ/IS-affiliated local groups’ attacks against civilians by 17.45%. Non-religious groups thus exhibit more consistent reductions in civilian targeting following pledges in their country.

Table 2. Pledges and Local Groups’ Civilian Victimization by Group Ideology

	<i>DV: Civilian Victimization</i>					
	Sample: Religious Groups			Sample: Non-Religious		
	Model 4	Model 5	Model 6	Model 7	Model 8	Model 9
Average Treatment Effect	-0.1762 (0.1895)	-0.1229 (0.226)	-0.0842 (0.1431)	-0.192** (0.0959)	-0.1804* (0.1058)	-0.1917* (0.1057)
Time-Fixed Effects	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Unit-Fixed Effects	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
<i>Controls</i>						
Share of Transnational Attacks	No	Yes	Yes	No	Yes	Yes
Diversity of Attacks	No	Yes	Yes	No	Yes	Yes
Kidnapping/Extortion	No	Yes	Yes	No	Yes	Yes
Leader Decapitation	No	No	No	No	No	Yes
Group Age (logged)	No	No	No	No	No	Yes
N	624	585	585	1742	1716	1716

Note 1: ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.1$

Note 2: Robust standard errors clustered on group are in parentheses. All models are estimated with Callaway and Sant’Anna’s (2021) doubly robust estimation method for staggered Difference-in-Differences using the `att_gt` function of the `did` package in R. All models consider both “Never Treated” and “Not Yet Treated” units as the control group.

Figure 5 extends this analysis through event studies using Models 4 and 7. The left panel plots dynamic treatment effects for religious groups, while the right panel does so for non-religious groups. The left panel shows religious groups maintaining parallel trends pre-treatment, but post-treatment declines fail to achieve statistical significance, even at the 90% level.

In contrast, the right panel illustrates stronger patterns for non-religious groups (72 percent of

our groups). Pre-treatment effects hover around zero, supporting parallel trends. Post-treatment effects reveal sustained reductions in civilian targeting, achieving 95% significance (blue markers) starting from year 3 onward. Taken together, these results provide support for H2, which posits ideological distance as a key moderating factor in shaping local groups' responses to transnational jihadist competition. Ideologically distant groups (non-religious) demonstrate more pronounced and sustained restraint in response to competition from transnational jihadists, while religious groups—who may struggle to construct meaningful contrasts with transnational jihadists—exhibit weaker responses.

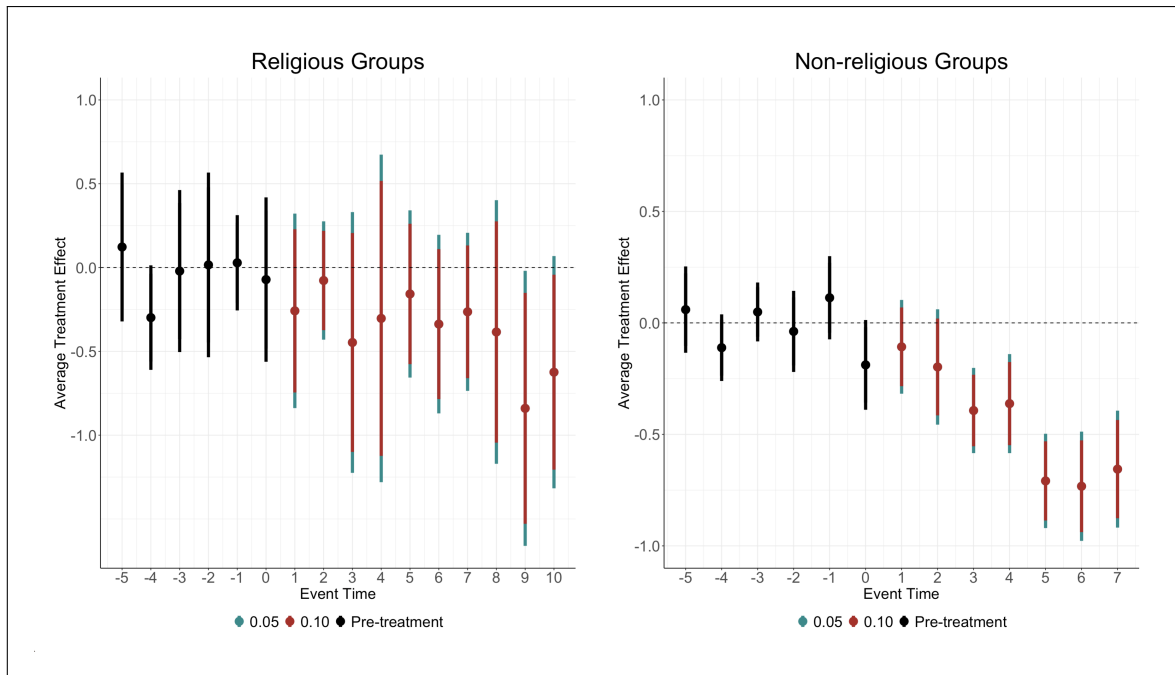


Figure 5. Aggregate Group-Time Average Treatment Effects by Group Ideology
Note: Event study is based on Models 4 and 7 of Table 2. Dynamic group-time average treatment effects are computed using the `aggte` function of the `did` package in R.

Heterogeneous Treatment Effects by Terrorist Designation

We further test whether the effects of pledges depend on non-AQ/IS-affiliated groups' terrorist designation status (H3). Specifically, we hypothesize that non-designated groups, facing greater reputational incentives, will moderate violence more than designated groups. Separate DiD models analyze designated ($N = 37$) and non-designated groups ($N = 448$). Table 3 reports results.

Among designated groups (Models 10–12), ATEs are negative but statistically insignificant. This aligns with expectations, as designated groups face limited prospects for reputational improvement. By contrast, non-designated groups (Models 13–15) exhibit significant reductions in

civilian victimization, supporting H3. The ATEs are negative and significant at conventional levels across specifications, with Model 15 estimating a 20.6% decrease in civilian targeting by non-designated non-AQ/IS-affiliated local groups following a pledge in their country.

Table 3. Pledges and Local Groups’ Civilian Victimization by Designation Status

	<i>DV: Civilian Victimization</i>					
	Sample: Designated Groups			Sample: Non-Designated		
	Model 10	Model 11	Model 12	Model 13	Model 14	Model 15
Average Treatment Effect	-0.3609 (0.36)	-0.0075 (0.4146)	-0.531 (0.5953)	-0.1886** (0.0911)	-0.2054** (0.1019)	-0.2307** (0.1149)
Time-Fixed Effects	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Unit-Fixed Effects	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
<i>Controls</i>						
Share of Transnational Attacks	No	Yes	Yes	No	Yes	Yes
Diversity of Attacks	No	Yes	Yes	No	Yes	Yes
Kidnapping/Extortion	No	Yes	Yes	No	Yes	Yes
Leader Decapitation	No	No	No	No	No	Yes
Group Age (logged)	No	No	No	No	No	Yes
N	234	234	234	2067	2002	2002

Note 1: **p < 0.05, *p < 0.1

Note 2: Robust standard errors clustered on group are in parentheses. All models are estimated with Callaway and Sant’Anna’s (2021) doubly robust estimation method for staggered Difference-in-Differences using the `att_gt` function of the `did` package in R. All models consider both “Never Treated” and “Not Yet Treated” units as the control group.

The event study results in Figure 6 corroborate these findings. For designated groups (left panel), post-treatment effects remain insignificant, reinforcing the lack of moderation. In contrast, non-designated groups (right panel) exhibit significant and sustained reductions, reaching 95% confidence (blue markers) by years 5–7 and again in year 9. These results underscore the importance of designation status. Non-designated groups—motivated by greater prospects for reputational improvement—demonstrate restraint toward civilians, potentially leveraging competition with transnational jihadists to enhance their international appeal.

Discussion on Scope

Our findings on restrained competition likely apply to a substantial and diverse subset of armed groups. Of the 485 groups in our dataset, 159 (33%) are non-religious, non-designated, and operate in countries with at least one AQ or IS affiliate—indicating that the scope of restrained competition is far from marginal. About half of these groups are based in South Asia, with additional concentrations in the Middle East and North Africa (19%), sub-Saharan Africa (19%), Russia (4%), and Southeast Asia (3%), while a few operate across multiple regions.

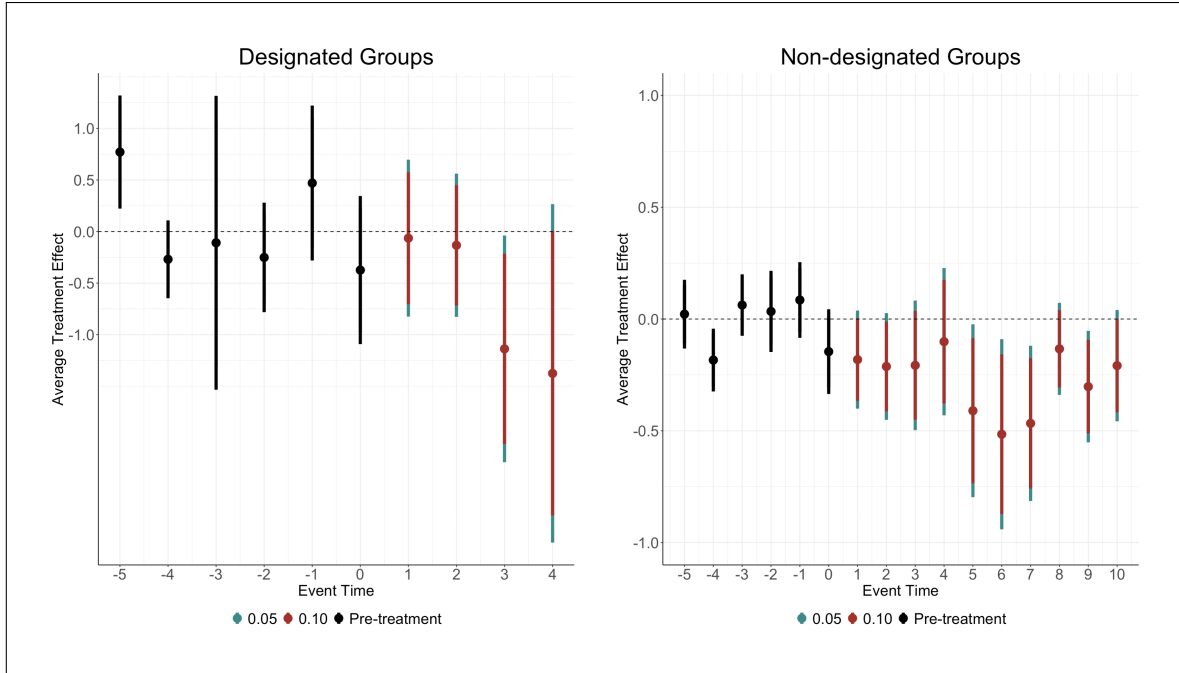


Figure 6. Aggregate Group-Time Average Treatment Effects by Designation Status
Note: Event study is based on Models 10 and 13 of Table 3. Dynamic group-time average treatment effects are computed using the `aggte` function of the `did` package in R.

These actors vary widely in size, capability, and political orientation. Examples include M23 in the DRC (a militarily effective center-seeking group), the ONLF in Ethiopia (moderately-sized secessionist group, NSCN-K in India and Myanmar (a transnational insurgency). Other cases include CPI-M in India (a Marxist revolutionary force, the Kurdistan Freedom Hawks in Turkey (a smaller group engaged in suicide terrorism), Syrian Democratic Forces (a large multiethnic alliance that directly confronts ISIS), Free Aceh Movement in Indonesia (a large diaspora network in Europe). The variation across these cases underscores the broader relevance of our argument and its applicability beyond a narrow slice of the armed group universe.

While both terrorist designation and ideology shape the dynamics of restrained competition, our results suggest designation status is a more robust moderator. Non-designated groups consistently show stronger and more statistically significant reductions in civilian victimization, while effects for non-religious groups, though consistent with our theory, hover around the 90% confidence level. Thus, restrained competition appears most likely among groups that are both non-designated and ideologically distinct from AQ or IS affiliates.

Robustness and Extensions

Alternative Measures

We estimate a series of negative binomial regression models as robustness checks. As shown in the Appendix, the results remain consistent.

We use two alternative measures of civilian victimization: (a) the *logged number of civilian casualties* and (b) the *logged number of casualties per attack targeting civilians*. Results (Appendix 5) closely mirror those of our primary analysis.

We also employ an alternative measure of group ideology: strategic vs. universalist groups, using data collected by Piazza (2009) and extended by Hand and Saiya (2022). Piazza (2009, 65) defines universalist groups as those with “highly ambitious, abstract, complex, and nebulous goals”, aligning closely with the transnational aims of jihadist groups. Using this proxy, we replicate our main findings. Pledges lead strategic groups to reduce civilian victimization, while universalist groups do not (Appendix 5).

To address concerns that pledging groups formed through splintering may represent different dynamics—introducing new actors in addition to altering the behavior of existing ones—we re-estimate all models after excluding eight post-splinter pledge cases from our treatment. Results remain substantively unchanged (Appendix 15).

Target Specificity of Restraint

To assess whether the observed decline in civilian targeting simply reflects a broader reduction in overall armed activity, we examine attacks against police and military targets (Appendix 16). Once group-level controls are included, we find no consistent evidence of decreased violence against these targets following pledges, not even among non-religious or non-designated local groups. In some cases—such as among designated groups—violence against state actors increases. These patterns suggest that the observed restraint toward civilians is not simply a byproduct of declining activity.

Resource-Centric Concerns

Although our DiD models capture within-group changes over time, we also address potential confounding from time-varying group-level factors. We control for two factors that plausibly shape civilian victimization—*foreign state support* (a proxy of reduced dependence on local populations) and *social service provision* (a proxy of greater concern for local populations). Both measures are derived from the EDTG dataset. Results (Appendix 6 and 7) remain consistent with our main

findings, indicating that observed restraint is not driven by shifts in group resources or population-oriented strategies.

Militant Infighting

Militant infighting—violence between armed groups—can induce restraint by intensifying resource pressures and increasing groups’ dependence on civilians¹⁰⁰. If non-AQ/IS-affiliated groups frequently clash with AQ/IS affiliates, observed restraint might reflect resource reallocation to infighting rather than AQ/IS affiliates changing the “rule of competition”.

To account for this, we control for the propensity of non-AQ/IS-affiliated groups to attack other armed groups, using the GTD’s target-type indicators. Results (Appendix 12) remain consistent. We also re-estimate our models using only group-years with minimal infighting. Even in these cases, non-religious and non-designated groups continue to exhibit restraint following pledges, indicating that the observed effects are not solely driven by militant infighting.

Organizational Capacity and Territorial Aspirations

We further test robustness by controlling for two group-level factors related to our causal mechanism: non-AQ/IS affiliated groups’ *organizational strength* and *secessionist goals*. Both measures are derived from the EDTG.

Weaker groups may be unable to escalate violence if AQ/IS-affiliated rivals outcompete them for recruits, funding, or territory—raising the possibility that restraint stems from limited capacity rather than deliberate moderation. Likewise, secessionist groups may be especially vulnerable to competition from AQ/IS affiliates, who could directly threaten their territorial ambitions. After controlling for both factors, our results (Appendix 8 and 9) remain unchanged.

Transnational Jihadist Brutality

Our theory posits that transnational jihadists’ extreme violence serves as a competitive reference point, reshaping the “rules of competition” and prompting restraint among local rivals. To account for this aspect of the theory, we use the GTD to calculate the *logged number of civilian casualties caused by pledged AQ/IS-affiliated groups* per country-year—capturing the brutality of these actors. We merge this measure with our dataset, linking it to non-AQ/IS-affiliated groups operating in the same country, and include it as a control in our DiD models. Results (Appendix 10) remain consistent.

¹⁰⁰(Polo and Welsh 2024)

Spatial Substitution

We also consider the possibility of spatial substitution—that non-AQ/IS-affiliated groups might shift civilian targeting across borders rather than reduce it, to avoid competition with transnational jihadists. If so, the observed decline in local victimization could reflect geographic displacement rather than restraint. To mitigate this, we re-estimate our DiD models using the *logged number of cross-border civilian attacks* as the outcome (Appendix 11). The consistency of our main findings strengthens the argument that the observed effects are not driven by geographic displacement.

Discussion and Conclusion

This study sheds new light on the strategic behavior of armed groups, challenging common assumptions about competition and violent escalation. Contrary to expectations that competition inherently drives escalation, this study revealed that competition with certain rivals does not always prompt armed groups to resort to increased violence against civilians. These findings also contribute to broader debates about how armed groups balance violence with aspirations for maintaining legitimacy¹⁰¹, showcasing how these aspirations shape groups’ behavioral responses to inter-group competition. While not all groups prioritize reputation, groups with greater prospects for enhancing their reputations—such as those not burdened by terrorist designations—demonstrate stronger incentives to moderate violence under competitive pressures.

These insights hold important implications for policymakers grappling with the rise of transnational organizations like AQ and IS. Concerns about outbidding dynamics—where local groups escalate violence to compete with transnational jihadists—have shaped policy debates¹⁰². Our findings suggest that escalation is not inevitable. Instead, competition may, in some cases, push groups to adopt more restrained approaches to maintain civilian support and bolster international appeal. Recognizing these dynamics can inform counterterrorism strategies that avoid reinforcing stigmatization and incentivize moderation.

Future research could build on this study in several ways. First, future work could expand our focus on the *type* of actor inducing competition in a violent political market to include other types of actors—beyond transnational jihadists—who could plausibly alter the “rules of competition”. For instance, international criminal organizations and cartel-like networks operating in gray zones between political and economic violence may shape competition in ways scholars have not yet considered¹⁰³.

¹⁰¹(Jo 2015; Stanton 2016; Fazal and Konaev 2019; Stanton 2020)

¹⁰²(Hamming 2020; Berlin 2024)

¹⁰³(Gilbert 2024)

Second, while this study highlights violent tactics, further work is needed to examine how competition with transnational jihadists affects local groups' non-violent practices, such as governance strategies, service provision, and relationships with state actors. Analyzing changes in discourse, propaganda, and public messaging could also illuminate how groups discursively highlight differences from extremist actors to mobilize support under competitive pressures.

Third, additional research should continue to study armed organizations that espouse religious ideologies. While our findings suggest that religious groups did not significantly moderate in response to pledges to AQ or IS in their country, neither did they escalate civilian targeting. This challenges common assumptions that religious ideologies inherently produce groups indifferent to public judgment. Understanding these dynamics remains a pressing concern due to the number of fragmented civil wars in the international system.

References

- Ahmad, Aisha. 2019. “‘We Have Captured Your Women’: Explaining Jihadist Norm Change.” *International Security* 44(1):80–116.
- Asal, Victor, Brian J Phillips and R Karl Rethemeyer. 2022. *Insurgent Terrorism: Intergroup Relationships and the Killing of Civilians*. Oxford University Press.
- Asal, Victor, Christopher Linebarger, Amira Jadoon and J Michael Greig. 2023. Why Some Rebel Organizations Attack Americans. In *On Terrorist Groups*. Routledge pp. 72–89.
- Asal, Victor H and R Karl Rethemeyer. 2015. “Big allied and dangerous dataset version 2.” Available for browsing at <http://www.start.umd.edu/baad/database>.
- Autor, David. 2003. “Outsourcing at Will: The Contribution of Unjust Dismissal Doctrine to the Growth of Employment Outsourcing.” *Journal of Labor Economics* 21(1):1–42.
- Bacon, Tricia. 2018. *Why Terrorist Groups Form International Alliances*. University of Pennsylvania Press.
- Balcells, Laia and Jessica A Stanton. 2021. “Violence Against Civilians During Armed Conflict: Moving Beyond the Macro-and Micro-Level Divide.” *Annual Review of Political Science* 24(1):45–69.
- BBC. 2020. “Militant Islamists ‘Behead More than 50’ in Mozambique.”
- Belgioioso, Margherita. 2018. “Going Underground: Resort to Terrorism in Mass Mobilization Dissident Campaigns.” *Journal of Peace Research* 55(5):641–655.
- Belgioioso, Margherita and Ches Thurber. 2024. “From Doctrine to Detonation: Ideology, Competition, and Terrorism in Campaigns of Mass Resistance.” *Journal of Peace Research* 61(3):333–350.
- Berlin, Mark Stephen. 2024. Pledging allegiance to al-Qaeda and the Islamic state: The causes and consequences of rhetorical cooperation PhD thesis The George Washington University.
- Berlin, Mark and Stephen Rangazas. 2023. “Restrained Insurgents: Why Competition Between Armed Groups Doesn’t Always Produce Outbidding.” *Texas National Security Review* 6(4):11–36.
- Biberman, Yelena and Farhan Zahid. 2019. “Why Terrorists Target Children: Outbidding, Desperation, and Extremism in the Peshawar and Beslan School Massacres.” *Terrorism and Political Violence* 31(2):169–184.
- Blair, Christopher W, Erica Chenoweth, Michael C Horowitz, Evan Perkoski and Philip BK Potter. 2022. “Honor Among Thieves: Understanding Rhetorical and Material Cooperation Among Violent Nonstate Actors.” *International Organization* 76(1):164–203.
- Blair, Christopher W and Philip BK Potter. 2023. “The strategic logic of large militant alliance networks.” *Journal of Global Security Studies* 8(1):ogac035.

- Bloom, Mia. 2005. *Dying to Kill: The Allure of Suicide Terror*. Columbia University Press.
- Bloom, Mia M. 2004. "Palestinian Suicide Bombing: Public Support, Market Share, and Outbidding." *Political Science Quarterly* 119(1):61–88.
- Brandt, Caroline and Jenniina Kotajoki. 2023. "Naming and Shaming of Non-State Armed Groups." Working Paper.
- Breslawski, Jori and Brandon Ives. 2019. "Killing for god? Factional violence on the transnational stage." *Journal of Conflict Resolution* 63(3):617–643.
- Brzezinski, Marek K. 2024. "A theory of jihadist beheadings." *Journal of Peace Research* 61:778–793.
- Busher, Joel and Tore Bjørgo. 2020. "Restraint in Terrorist Groups and Radical Milieus." *Perspectives on Terrorism* 14(6):2–13.
- Búzás, Zoltán I and Anna A Meier. 2023. "Racism by Designation: Making Sense of Western States' Nondesignation of White Supremacists as Terrorists." *Security Studies* 32(4-5):680–713.
- Byman, Daniel. 2014. "Buddies or burdens? Understanding the Al Qaeda relationship with its affiliate organizations." *Security Studies* 23(3):431–470.
- Callaway, Brantly and Pedro H.C. Sant'Anna. 2021. "Difference-in-Differences with Multiple Time Periods." *Journal of Econometrics* 225(2):200–230.
- Conrad, Justin and Kevin Greene. 2015. "Competition, Differentiation, and the Severity of Terrorist Attacks." *The Journal of Politics* 77(2):546–561.
- Conrad, Justin, Kevin T Greene and Brian J Phillips. 2023. "Introducing ViNSAR: Dyadic Data on Violent Non-state Actor Rivalry." *Journal of Conflict Resolution* 68:1884–1908.
- Conrad, Justin and William Spaniel. 2021a. *Militant Competition: How Terrorists and Insurgents Advertise with Violence and How They Can Be Stopped*. Cambridge University Press.
- Conrad, Justin and William Spaniel. 2021b. Outbidding as Deterrence: Endogenous Demands in the Shadow of Group Competition. In *Militant Competition: How Terrorists and Insurgents Advertise with Violence and How They Can Be Stopped*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press pp. 125–161.
- Crenshaw, Martha. 1987. "Theories of Terrorism: Instrumental and Organizational Approaches." *The Journal of Strategic Studies* 10(4):13–31.
- Crenshaw, Martha. 2010. "Mapping terrorist organizations." *Unpublished working paper* 256.
- Crisman-Cox, Casey and Michael Gibilisco. 2024. "Tug of War: The Heterogeneous Effects of Outbidding between Terrorist Groups." *International Organization* . Forthcoming.
- Cronin, Audrey K. 2004. The 'FTO List' and Congress: Sanctioning Designated Foreign Terrorist Organizations. In *Foreign Terrorist Organizations: History, Tactics and Connections*, ed. Edward V. Linden. New York: Nova Science Publishers Inc. pp. 123–135.

- Cunningham, David E, Kristian Skrede Gleditsch and Idean Salehyan. 2013. "Non-state actors in civil wars: A new dataset." *Conflict management and peace science* 30(5):516–531.
- De la Calle, Luis. 2017. "Compliance vs. constraints: A theory of rebel targeting in civil war." *Journal of Peace Research* 54(3):427–441.
- Doctor, Austin C and John D Willingham. 2022. "Foreign fighters, rebel command structure, and civilian targeting in civil war." *Terrorism and Political Violence* 34(6):1125–1143.
- El Masri, Mirna and Brian J. Phillips. 2024. "Threat Perception, Policy Diffusion, and the Logic of Terrorist Group Designation." *Studies in Conflict & Terrorism* 47(8):838–861.
- Farrell, Megan. 2020. "The Logic of Transnational Outbidding: Pledging Allegiance and the Escalation of Violence." *Journal of Peace Research* 57(3):437–451.
- Fazal, Tanisha M. 2018. *Wars of law: Unintended consequences in the regulation of armed conflict*. Cornell University Press.
- Fazal, Tanisha M. 2021. "What You Fight for Shapes How You Fight." *Proceedings of the ASIL Annual Meeting* 115:58–60.
- Fazal, Tanisha M. and Margarita Konaev. 2019. "Homelands versus Minelands: Why Do Armed Groups Commit to the Laws of War?" *Journal of Global Security Studies* 4(2):149–168.
- Fearon, James D. 2017. "Civil war & the current international system." *Dædalus* 146(4):18–32.
- Findley, Michael G and Joseph K Young. 2012. "More Combatant Groups, More Terror?: Empirical Tests of an Outbidding Logic." *Terrorism and Political Violence* 24(5):706–721.
- Friis, Simone Molin. 2018. "'Behead, burn, crucify, crush': Theorizing the Islamic State's public displays of violence." *European Journal of International Relations* 24(2):243–267.
- Gade, Emily Kalah, Mohammed M Hafez and Michael Gabbay. 2019. "Fratricide in Rebel Movements: A Network Analysis of Syrian Militant Infighting." *Journal of Peace Research* 56(3):321–335.
- Ghazaleh, Pascale, Gilles Kepel and Jean-Pierre Milelli. 2008. *Al Qaeda in Its Own Words*. Harvard University Press.
- Gilbert, Danielle. 2024. "Partners in Crime: Comparative Advantage and Kidnapping Cooperation." *Comparative Political Studies* .
- Hamming, Tore Refslund. 2020. "The Al Qaeda–Islamic State rivalry: Competition yes, but no competitive escalation." *Terrorism and Political Violence* 32(1):20–37.
- Hand, Ashlyn W. and Nilay Saiya. 2022. "Democracy's Ambivalent Effect on Terrorism." *Journal of Conflict Resolution* 67(7-8):1618–1643. Published online December 4, 2022.
- Haspeslagh, Sophie. 2013. "'Listing terrorists': the impact of proscription on third-party efforts to engage armed groups in peace processes – a practitioner's perspective." *Critical Studies on Terrorism* 6(1):189–208.

- Haspeslagh, Sophie. 2021. *Proscribing Peace: How Listing Armed Groups as Terrorists Hurts Negotiations*. Manchester: Manchester University Press.
- Hassell, Hans J. G. and John B. Holbein. 2024. "Navigating Potential Pitfalls in Difference-in-Differences Designs: Reconciling Conflicting Findings on Mass Shootings' Effect on Electoral Outcomes." *American Political Science Review* pp. 1–21.
- Hegghammer, Thomas. 2009. "The ideological hybridization of jihadi groups." *Current Trends in Islamist Ideology* 9(1):26–45.
- Holtermann, Helge. 2019. "Diversionary rebel violence in territorial civil war." *International Studies Quarterly* 63(2):215–230.
- Hou, Dongfang, Khusrav Gaibulloev and Todd Sandler. 2020. "Introducing Extended Data on Terrorist Groups (EDTG), 1970 to 2016." *Journal of Conflict Resolution* 64(1):199–225.
- Huang, Reyko and Patricia L Sullivan. 2021. "Arms for education? External support and rebel social services." *Journal of Peace Research* 58(4):794–808.
- Huntington-Klein, Nick. 2022. Difference-in-Differences. In *The Effect: An Introduction to Research Design and Causality*. 1st ed. Chapman & Hall p. 646. 162 B/W Illustrations.
- Jadoon, Amira. 2018. "Allied & Lethal: Islamic State Khorasan's network and organizational capacity in Afghanistan and Pakistan." *Combatting Terrorism Center at West Point* .
- Jadoon, Amira, Nakissa Jahanbani and Emma Fruchtman. 2023. "The uninvited guest: understanding Islamic State's alliances and rivalries in the Afghanistan-Pakistan region." *Asian Security* 19(1):59–81.
- Jo, Hyeran. 2015. *Compliant Rebels: Rebel Groups and International Law in World Politics*. New York: Cambridge University Press.
- Jo, Hyeran and Beth A. Simmons. 2016. "Can the International Criminal Court Deter Atrocity?" *International Organization* 70(3):443–475.
- Jo, Hyeran, Brian J. Phillips and Joshua Alley. 2020. Can Blacklisting Reduce Terrorist Attacks?: The Case of the US Foreign Terrorist Organization (FTO) List. In *The Power of Global Performance Indicators*, ed. Judith G. Kelley and Beth A. Simmons. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press pp. 271–299.
- Jones, Seth G and Martin C Libicki. 2008. *How terrorist groups end: Lessons for countering al Qaeda*. Rand Corporation.
- Kalyvas, Stathis N. 2006. *The logic of violence in civil war*. Cambridge University Press.
- Kalyvas, Stathis N. 2018. "Jihadi Rebels in Civil War." *Daedalus* 147(1):36–47.
- Krause, Dino. 2024. "Armed Conflicts With Al-Qaeda and the Islamic State: The Role of Repression and State Capacity." *Journal of Conflict Resolution* 68(2-3):456–483.
- Kydd, Andrew H and Barbara F Walter. 2006. "The Strategies of Terrorism." *International Security* 31(1):49–80.

- Levy, Gabriella, Rebecca Dudley and David A. Siegel. 2024. "Diplomatic Statements and the Strategic Use of Terrorism in Civil Wars." *Journal of Conflict Resolution* . First published online February 5, 2024.
- Lewis, Janet I. 2023. "Rebel Group Formation in Africa: Evidence from a New Dataset." *World Development* 170:106207.
- Lynch, Marc. 2017. "In the Same Basket, or Not? The White House has recently hosted two very different views about how to deal with Islamism." *Diwan: Carnegie Endowment for International Peace's Middle East Program* .
- Lynch, Marc, Jeroen Gunning and Morten Valbjørn. 2024. "Changing Warscapes, Changing Islamists? Religion, Organization, Strategic Context and New Approaches to Armed Islamist Insurgencies." *Studies in Conflict & Terrorism* pp. 1–24.
- Macklin, Graham. 2020. "The Internal Brakes on Violent Escalation Within the British Extreme Right in the 1990s." *Perspectives on Terrorism* 14(6):49–64.
- Malone, Iris. 2022. "Unmasking Militants: Organizational Trends in Armed Groups, 1970–2012." *International Studies Quarterly* 66(3):sqac050.
- Melander, Erik, Therése Pettersson and Lotta Themnér. 2016. "Organized violence, 1989–2015." *Journal of Peace Research* 53(5):727–742.
- Mendelsohn, Barak. 2015. *The al-Qaeda Franchise: the Expansion of al-Qaeda and its Consequences*. Oxford University Press.
- Moghadam, Assaf. 2009. "Motives for martyrdom: Al-Qaida, Salafi Jihad, and the spread of suicide attacks." *International Security* 33(3):46–78.
- Murdie, Amanda and Craig S Stapley. 2014. "Why Target the "Good Guys"? The Determinants of Terrorism Against NGOs." *International Interactions* 40(1):79–102.
- Nemeth, Stephen. 2014. "The effect of competition on terrorist group operations." *Journal of Conflict Resolution* 58(2):336–362.
- Okado-Gough, Damien. 2003. "Real Irish Republican Army (rIRA) Statement." *Channel 9 TV News* .
- Onder, Ilayda B. 2024. "Target Hardening and Non-state Armed Groups' Target Selection: Evidence from India." *Terrorism and Political Violence* 36(8):1105–1126.
- Oswald, Christian, Melanie Sauter, Sigrid Weber and Rob Williams. 2020. "Under the roof of rebels: Civilian targeting after territorial takeover in Sierra Leone." *International Studies Quarterly* 64(2):295–305.
- Pettersson, Therése and Magnus Öberg. 2020. "Organized violence, 1989–2019." *Journal of peace research* 57(4):597–613.
- Phillips, Brian J. 2015. "Enemies with Benefits? Violent Rivalry and Terrorist Group Longevity." *Journal of Peace Research* 52(1):62–75.

- Phillips, Brian J. 2019. "Foreign Terrorist Organization designation, international cooperation, and terrorism." *International Interactions* 45(2):316–343.
- Piazza, James A. 2009. "Is Islamist terrorism more dangerous?: An empirical study of group ideology, organization, and goal structure." *Terrorism and Political Violence* 21(1):62–88.
- Polo, Sara MT. 2020. "The quality of terrorist violence: Explaining the logic of terrorist target choice." *Journal of peace research* 57(2):235–250.
- Polo, Sara M.T. and Blair Welsh. 2024. "Violent Competition and Terrorist Restraint." *International Organization* pp. 1–30.
- Salehyan, Idean, David Siroky and Reed M. Wood. 2014. "External Rebel Sponsorship and Civilian Abuse: A Principal-Agent Analysis of Wartime Atrocities." *International Organization* 68(3):633–661.
- Sanchez-Cuenca, Ignacio. 2007. "The Dynamics of Nationalist Terrorism: ETA and the IRA." *Terrorism and Political Violence* 19(3):289–306.
- Sanín, Francisco Gutiérrez and Elisabeth Jean Wood. 2014. "Ideology in civil war: Instrumental adoption and beyond." *Journal of Peace Research* 51(2):213–226.
- Schwab, Regine. 2023. "Same same but different? Ideological differentiation and intra-jihadist competition in the Syrian civil war." *Journal of Global Security Studies* 8(1):ogac045.
- Stanton, Jessica A. 2013. "Terrorism in the context of civil war." *The Journal of Politics* 75(4):1009–1022.
- Stanton, Jessica A. 2016. *Violence and Restraint in Civil War: Civilian Targeting in the Shadow of International Law*. New York: Cambridge University Press.
- Stanton, Jessica A. 2020. "Rebel groups, international humanitarian law, and civil war outcomes in the post-Cold War era." *International Organization* 74(3):523–559.
- Stewart, Megan A. 2018. "Civil War as State-Making: Strategic Governance in Civil War." *International Organization* 72(1):205–226.
- Svensson, Isak and Desirée Nilsson. 2018. "Disputes over the divine: Introducing the religion and armed conflict (relac) data, 1975 to 2015." *Journal of Conflict Resolution* 62(5):1127–1148.
- Tokdemir, Efe, Evgeny Sedashov, Sema Hande Ogutcu-Fu, Carlos E Moreno Leon, Jeremy Berkowitz and Seden Akcinaroglu. 2021. "Rebel rivalry and the strategic nature of rebel group ideology and demands." *Journal of Conflict Resolution* 65(4):729–758.
- Tominaga, Yasutaka, Chia-yi Lee and Mengting Lyu. 2022. "Introducing a new dataset on Designated Terrorist Organizations (DTO)." *Journal of Peace Research* 59(5):756–766.
- Tschantret, Joshua. 2018. "Cleansing the Caliphate: Insurgent Violence Against Sexual Minorities." *International Studies Quarterly* 62(2):260–273.
- Ugarriza, Juan E. and Craig J. Matthew. 2013. "The Relevance of Ideology to Contemporary

- Armed Conflicts: A Quantitative Analysis of Former Combatants in Colombia.” *Journal of Conflict Resolution* 57(3):445–477.
- Walter, Barbara F. 2017. “The new new civil wars.” *Annual Review of Political Science* 20(1):469–486.
- Warner, Jason, Ryan O’Farrell, Heni Nsaibia and Ryan Cummings. 2022. *The Islamic State in Africa: The Emergence, Evolution, and Future of the Next Jihadist Battlefield*. Oxford University Press.
- Weinstein, Jeremy M. 2006. *Inside rebellion: The politics of insurgent violence*. Cambridge University Press.
- Wood, Reed M. 2010. “Rebel capability and strategic violence against civilians.” *Journal of Peace Research* 47(5):601–614.
- Wood, Reed M and Jacob D Kathman. 2015. “Competing for the crown: Inter-rebel competition and civilian targeting in civil war.” *Political Research Quarterly* 68(1):167–179.
- Ying, L. 2024. “Military power and ideological appeals of religious extremists.” *Journal of Politics* .